Homewise VOC Synthesis: 8 Interviews

For design + frontend handoff

SAMPLE QUALITY NOTE

Target audience reminder: Homewise serves anyone who needs to hire a contractor for a job, regardless of how long they have owned their home. New homeowners are not inherently the target — a new homeowner may be handy and never hire anyone, while an experienced homeowner may have just lost their go-to plumber and need to find a new trusted one. The trigger is the job, not the tenure.

Of 8 interviews, 6 are homeowners and 2 are renters (Interviews #2 and #8). The renter interviews remain directional only — they corroborate pain points but do not validate the homeowner journey we are designing for.

The 6 homeowners span the full hiring spectrum: large remodels (Interview #3, $100K), mid-size projects (Interview #4 yard, $10K; Interview #1 siding, ~$7K), and smaller repair/diagnostic jobs (TC#3 handyman, TC#4 tile, Interview #9 electrical). This range matches the actual product surface area. Sample is small but the pain patterns are consistent across job sizes — directional findings, not representative.

FINDING 1: Trust starts social, not digital

Across the homeowner sample, the first move for finding a contractor is almost never a marketplace. It is a neighbor, a friend, a contractor seen working down the street, or social media. Yelp, Angi, and Thumbtack come up only when the social channel fails — and when they are used (Interviews #1, TC#2, TC#4), satisfaction is consistently lower.

TC#3 was explicit: he distrusts Yelp reviews entirely because he believes they can be paid for or gamed. TC#4 said word of mouth is the strongest signal, full stop. Interview #4 hired the contractor she saw working on her neighbor’s yard without contacting anyone else.

Design implication: Homewise cannot win by being a better-looking rating aggregator. The product needs to feel like a trusted referral — the AI is doing what a knowledgeable friend would do, not what a search engine does. The contractor showcase (Flow 3) is the right mechanism. The "Recommended by N Homewisers" framing is closer to social proof than to star ratings, and we should protect that distinction in the UI.

FINDING 2: Scope uncertainty is the actual problem. Price is the symptom.

Every participant who felt uncertain about price was actually uncertain about scope. This finding is now stronger with the additional interviews:

- Interview #1 (siding): quotes ranged $250 to $7,000 for the same issue, because contractors proposed fundamentally different interventions.
- TC#4 (backsplash): quotes ranged $400 to $2,500 for a small tile job. She had to text contractors back and forth asking why their quotes differed.

- Interview #9 (electrical): "every company explained the issue differently."
- Interview #8 (plumbing, renter): "different plumbers quoted very different amounts for what sounded like the same problem."

Interview #1’s own proposed solution was striking: hire a diagnostic-only expert, generate a defined scope, then solicit comparable quotes. That is essentially Flow 2 of the product. He also identified the market resistance — contractors do not want to be paid for diagnosis only, or to follow externally defined scope. That tells us this is not a UX problem alone; it is a contractor-incentive problem we will have to engineer around.

Design implication: The scope-of-work artifact in Flow 2 (Step 2) is the most important deliverable in the entire product, more than the contractor list. It needs to feel authoritative, comparable, and editable. Treat its presentation as a first-class screen, not a modal or a hidden detail. Unit pricing for scope-uncertain items (the "siding rot" pattern) should be visible in the homeowner’s view, not hidden in the contractor bid form.

FINDING 3: Communication volume is a top-3 pain — new theme

This finding is new and worth surfacing sharply for design.

TC#4 named "constant back-and-forth" as the most frustrating part of the experience — she and her husband tag-team contractor communication because the volume is too much for one person. Every contractor wanted to come to the house to give an estimate, which compounded the load. TC#3 said his main filter for picking contractors is who responds first, because the communication overhead is so high he optimizes for speed over fit. Interview #8 described "many phone calls just to compare prices." Interview #9 described "spending a lot of time calling different electricians, explaining the same problem repeatedly."

Design implication: The "one scope sent to every contractor" model in Flow 2 (Step 5) directly attacks this pain. We should make this benefit visible to the user during onboarding and at the moment of approving outreach — not hidden as a backend optimization. The status board in Flow 2 (Step 6) also matters here: the user wants to know what is happening without having to chase it. Make status changes feel like updates the product is doing for them, not work the user has to track.

FINDING 4: Verification behavior splits by experience — and has a ceiling

Verification behavior across the sample:

- Interview #2 (renter): Yelp ratings only.
- Interview #8 (renter): online reviews + asked if licensed.
- Interview #4: noticed license number on business card. No further check.
- Interview #3: asked contractor for license and insurance info directly.
- TC#3 and TC#4: do not check for small jobs; check for big ones. TC#4 only started checking after a contractor experience went to court.
- Interview #9: checked license online, confirmed insurance.

- Interview #1: full check — license, insurance, bond, used AI to find the right verification sites.

No one spontaneously checked permit history. The depth layer (Shovels.ai-style permit data) only matters to users who already know they want it. The surface layer ("Verified by Homewise") has to do the work for everyone else.

Design implication: Progressive disclosure on verification is correct, but the default "Verified by Homewise" badge needs to carry visible weight. Consider showing the verification breakdown (license ✓, insurance ✓, permit history ✓) inline in the contractor comparison table, not behind a tap. For experienced users who want depth, the showcase panel is the right place to surface permit history. For everyone else, the badge does the trust work.

FINDING 5: Quote comparison is broken by design — and users know it

Interview #1 explicitly reached for ChatGPT to compare quotes and found the output not actionable. TC#4 said she would ask ChatGPT for a price range today, but couldn't when she did her project. Several users have tried AI tools for this exact problem and given up because the inputs (the quotes themselves) are not comparable.

Interview #1 surfaced an important market signal: a friend's product targeting this problem works only for highly standardized tasks (gutter cleaning, fence painting) where scope is measurable. It is reportedly profitable. This suggests the viable near-term version of Homewise may need to start with task categories where scope is definable, then expand into complex diagnostic scenarios as the AI capability matures.

Design implication: The "apples-to-apples comparison" in Flow 2 (Step 6) is the product's competitive moat. It must be obvious, fast to read, and trustworthy. Outlier flags, scope-deviation flags, and the plain-language summary are all critical — none of them are nice-to-haves. For MVP scope, consider whether we narrow to a few job categories where we have high scope-definition confidence, rather than spreading thin.

FINDING 6: The job is not done when the contractor is hired

Interview #3 (bathroom remodel) had major budget overruns because the contractor handed her a stack of receipts to reimburse at the end. She now wishes she had chosen a full-service contract. Interview #4 (yard renovation) got the wrong color materials and had waste as a result. Both wanted more control over execution, not just hiring.

The pitch line "you just say yes, Homewise handles the rest" implies the job ends at hiring. These users tell us execution-layer failures are real and underexplored. Flow 3 (Job Completion) is on the right track by closing the loop with confirmation and showcase, but we may need to think harder about the in-job experience between hiring and completion — particularly around material decisions and budget tracking. Likely V2, but worth flagging.

Design implication: For MVP, Flow 3 closes the loop visually (confirmation + recommendation + showcase) but the homeowner's experience between Step 7 (booking) and Step 1 of Flow 3 (contractor marks complete) is largely undefined. Designers should consider what the "job in progress" view looks like — even a simple status timeline would reduce the "what is happening?" anxiety these users described. Materials and budget tracking are V2 candidates but should not be designed away entirely.

RECURRING LANGUAGE

Words and phrases that came up across multiple interviews. Designers may want to pull from these for copy and microcopy:

- "Stressful" / "time-consuming" / "non-transparent" (#2, #3, #8, #9)
- "Finding the right person is the hardest part" (TC#3, TC#4 — both used this exact framing in wrap-up)
- "I had to make many phone calls" (#8, #9, multiple)
- "You can't really know if the price is fair" (#1, #2, TC#4, #8, #9 — universal)
- "Constant back-and-forth" (TC#4)
- "Word of mouth" / "neighbors" / "friends" (TC#3, TC#4, #4, #9 — preferred discovery channel)